

The 6:15

WEDNESDAY · SEPTEMBER 16, 2026

NO. 15

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Wed 9/16	FOMC decision 2p ET, presser 2:30p, SEP/dot plot — CME FedWatch prices a 25bp hike to 3.75-4.00% at 92-93% (Tue close) [see Lead] — would be the first hike since 2023. Aft. close: Lennar Q3 earnings, cons. \$1.28 EPS, rev. ~\$8.32B; call Thu 9/17, 11a ET.
Fri 9/18	FedEx earnings (aft. close), cons. EPS \$4.28-4.38, rev. ~\$23.1B [carried from last issue, not reverified this run] .
Sat 9/19	Northwestern hosts Colorado, Martin Stadium, 6:30p CT (FOX/FS1) — first meeting since 1978.
[NET] Tue 9/22	SpaceX Starship Flight 14, 7:15a CT window — first orbital Starship flight, 26 Starlink V3 sats; FAA approval pending [DEVELOPING, date firmed from earlier 9/15/9/18 split] .
[NEW, retro.]	Mon 9/14: Supreme Court blocked Trump's mail-ballot restrictions for the 2026 midterms. Tue 9/15: Delaware Dem. Senate primary — Coons renominated 84%, faces Katz (R) Nov.; last primary of the cycle. Sun 9/14: Z.ai completed ~\$5B financing for next-gen GLM models.

METRICS · AS OF TUE 9/15 CLOSE UNLESS NOTED

Oil/rates/vol	Brent settled \$108.75 Tue, ~\$107.77 early Wed (range \$107.19-109.08); WTI unsettled this run, vendors diverge \$103.52-104.68 [flag] . 10Y closed 5.01% (touched 5.04%) — first close above 5% since July 2007. 2Y 4.39%, 30Y 5.25% (3:30p Tue snapshot). VIX ~17.2, DXY ~99.70, gold ~\$4,283/oz [single aggregator source, flag] .
Equities/Asia/gas	Dow 52,093.11 (-0.63%), S&P 500 7,585.73 (-0.45%), Nasdaq Comp. 25,981.57 (-0.78%) Tue — 3rd straight down session pre-Fed; futures ~7,666 pre-market

Wed. Asia (Wed): Nikkei 63,923 (+0.69%), Hang Seng 24,713.78 (+0.19%), CSI 300 4,480.26 (+0.68%). No fresher Europe close than Mon 9/14 **[stale]**. Gas \$4.3289/gal natl. avg (AAA) **[timestamp not independently confirmed]**.

Crude: ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month. Rates: Treasury/CME. Equities: exchange closes/CNBC.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure	Day 199 (straits.live, 9/16 1017Z) and globalsecurity.org's own Day 199 (posted 9/14) — the day-count gap flagged last issue has closed.
Transits	PortWatch via straits.live: 9/13 = 8 (9% of the 85/day baseline); 9/12 = 2; 9/15 prelim. = 4. IMF PortWatch's own 9/6 read: 6/day, consistent. Lloyd's List: no figure newer than the 8/26-9/1 ~12/day already reported [flag] .
Dark tankers	straits.live's screened-fleet read: 59 of 193 vessels AIS-dark in 24h (1.9x ambient dropout) — a narrower metric than last issue's 490-vessel "stranded" count; not comparable across issues [metric change] .
War-risk premia	Unchanged ~\$10.0M/VLCC (~40x pre-crisis, straits.live), quote now over a week old — aging, not fresh.
Strikes (72h)	Tanker El Gaia (Panama-flagged, Indian-crewed) struck near Hengam Island 9/13 — 13 of 14 crew rescued, 1 missing. Houthis continue consolidating the Yemeni Red Sea coast seized last issue; see Iran & Hormuz.

PortWatch's day-specific AIS counts, Lloyd's List's weekly aggregation, and straits.live's dark-fleet screen measure different populations over different windows — never netted or averaged.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Beat Twins 8-3 (9/14) and 8-1 (9/15) at Target Field [aggregate record unreconciled this run — see Sports] .
Knicks	Hart, on a reported \$60-62M/3-yr framework vs. his \$132M max eligibility, quipped "I'll take 131 instead" — extension still unsigned.

LEAD

10-YEAR TOPS 5% FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE 2007, HOURS BEFORE THE FED

The 10-year closes above 5% for the first time since 2007, hours before a Fed almost certain to hike into an oil shock the market just watched a diplomatic off-ramp close on

Tuesday did what Friday's oil-driven relief rally couldn't undo. The 10-year Treasury yield touched 5.04% intraday and closed at 5.01%, its first close above 5% since July 2007. [fact] The proximate trigger wasn't a new inflation print — it was the collapse of the one de-escalation catalyst markets had been leaning on since last week. Oman's foreign minister, Badr Albusaidi, announced Sept. 13 that the Salalah talks between Gulf Arab states and Iran — meant to produce a temporary arrangement letting commercial traffic back through Hormuz via a split Iranian-entry, Omani-exit corridor — were indefinitely postponed, one day before they were due to convene, "in the interests of consensus." [fact, CNN] No party has said what broke down.

With that off-ramp gone, oil resumed the climb Friday's meeting-hope reversal had briefly interrupted. Brent, which settled Friday at \$104.61, closed Tuesday around \$108.75 and was trading near \$107.77 in early Wednesday dealing — back inside the range that's held since the strait entered its seventh month of closure. [fact] WTI has no clean settle to report this run; two vendor feeds diverge, \$103.52 and \$104.68, a gap wide enough to flag rather than average. [flag] A tanker strike underscored that the underlying risk hadn't

moved: Iranian state media said the Panama-flagged, Indian-crewed products tanker El Gaia was hit near Hengam Island on Sept. 13, with 13 of 14 crew rescued and one still missing. [fact, CNN/CBS]

That combination — a stalled diplomatic track plus a fresh strike — is what pushed the long end through 5%, not a domestic data surprise. [read] The mechanism is direct: energy-driven inflation that was already running hot in Friday's CPI print (core +0.3% m/m, reported last issue) now has no near-term supply-side relief valve, which raises the odds the Fed has to lean harder and longer than a one-and-done hike. CME FedWatch has odds of today's 2 p.m. decision at 92-93% for a 25bp move to 3.75-4.00% — a hike that would be the first since 2023 and the first move of any kind since the Fed's July hold. [fact] The 2-year, at 4.39%, and 30-year, at 5.25% (both Tuesday 3:30 p.m. snapshots), show a curve that's risen across the board rather than flattened sharply — a different signature than Friday's session, when the short end reportedly moved harder than the long end. [read: the curve shape argues the market is now pricing a sustained tightening cycle, not just a single supply-shock response]

Equities read it as a threat rather than a formality being priced in. The Dow fell 0.63% to 52,093.11, the S&P 500 lost 0.45% to 7,585.73, and the Nasdaq dropped 0.78% to 25,981.57 — a third straight down session heading into the decision, a sharp reversal from Friday's snap-back rally that had treated the same Fed-hike odds as background noise next to hopes of Gulf diplomacy. [fact] The difference this time: there's no oil-reversal story to hide behind. S&P futures ticked up modestly pre-market Wednesday, but that looks more like positioning ahead of the 2:30 p.m. press conference than a read on the decision itself. [read]

The setup into today's statement is now the mirror image of what this issue flagged Friday. Then, the risk was the Fed hiking into a shock that might already be turning. Now, with the Salalah track stalled and a tanker freshly hit, the Fed is walking into a decision with the supply-side risk pointed the wrong way — meaning today's dot plot and Chair Warsh's press-conference language on the path beyond one hike matter more than the hike itself, which the market has already fully priced. [read] Watch specifically whether the SEP shows one hike-and-done or a series; a hawkish dot plot on top of a 92%-priced hike is the scenario that could push the 10-year toward levels not seen since before the 2008 financial crisis.

A 10-year above 5% is not an abstraction for the reader's portfolio: mortgage rates, corporate borrowing costs and Treasury refinancing costs all reprice off this level, and the move happened in a single session rather than drifting there over weeks — the kind of gap move that tends to force repositioning rather than allow it. [read] The last sustained period above 5% preceded the 2007-08 credit crisis, though the comparison is about the yield level, not the underlying cause; this move is oil- and geopolitics-driven, not a housing-credit event, and Lennar's earnings tonight (see Business) will be one of the first reads on whether builders are already underwriting a higher-for-longer rate path into their margin guidance. [read]

POLITICS

The Supreme Court on Sept. 14 blocked the Trump administration's bid to let the U.S. Postal Service withhold delivery of mail ballots under a new executive-order rule, ruling the change couldn't be applied to the 2026 midterms regardless of its underlying legality. [fact, confirmed across CNN, NBC, NPR, CNBC] Justice

Kavanaugh, joining the majority, wrote separately that the rule might fall within the Postal Service's statutory authority in principle but that state and local election officials lacked time to implement it before November. [fact] Trump called the ruling a "disaster" and a "big loss for Republicans." [fact] The decision is most consequential in the eight states — including California, Nevada and Oregon — that vote almost entirely by mail. [fact] Separately, Delaware's Sept. 15 Democratic Senate primary closed out the 2026 primary calendar: incumbent Chris Coons won renomination with 84% over three challengers and will face Republican Mike Katz in November. [fact, AP call]

ECONOMICS

Today's FOMC decision is covered in the Lead. The remaining question the Board doesn't capture: what the Summary of Economic Projections says about the path after one hike. Fed officials have held the funds rate at 3.50-3.75% since December, through a July meeting that also held despite the Hormuz-driven oil spike already underway; a move today would mark the first hike of Chair Warsh's tenure and the first Fed hike of any kind since 2023. [fact] Markets are pricing the move itself as near-certain; the dot plot's median path for 2027 — not today's 25bp — is what would move the curve further from here. The last time the Fed hiked into a supply shock rather than a demand-side overheating was arguably the 1970s oil embargoes, a comparison worth treating skeptically given how different the current account and dollar-reserve position is, but one likely to surface in today's press conference questions regardless. [read] No new CPI, PPI or claims data is scheduled this week beyond what last issue already covered from Friday's report.

BUSINESS

Oracle's post-earnings round trip continued past Friday's reversal: the stock is up roughly 10.7% over the past week even after giving back its premarket pop, as investors continue to reward its cloud-backlog beat and its ties to the OpenAI ecosystem — a read that's held up longer than the single-session reversal flagged last issue suggested. [NEW, read] Adobe's Friday recovery to \$252.23 has no fresher print located this run; nothing suggests either name has been the marginal driver of Tuesday's broader equity pullback, which read as macro- rather than earnings-led. [continuity]

Housing is the other data point due today: Lennar reports after the close, with consensus at \$1.28 EPS on revenue of roughly \$8.32B, a call that implies a mid-30s percentage EPS decline year-over-year and a home-sales gross margin guided to ~16%, down from 17.5% a year ago. [fact] Watch net orders, cancellation rates and incentive spend for a read on whether the current-rate environment is already cutting into builder margins — and note the timing: results land hours after a Fed decision that could push mortgage-linked rates higher still, meaning tonight's guidance language may already be stale by the time it's read. [read] FedEx follows Friday with a delivery-volume read that functions as a rough freight-demand proxy for the broader economy the Fed is trying to read in real time.

TECHNOLOGY

The OpenAI-Buckmaster dispute hardened with new specifics on both sides. Buckmaster alleges OpenAI's Sebastien Bubeck twice argued that his collaborator, Anthropic's Levent Alpöge, shouldn't be listed as a co-author because of his employer, and that Bubeck told him "why would you ruin your career?" when he pushed to make the

dispute public; Buckmaster also says OpenAI offered a choice between simultaneous publication crediting both groups or Buckmaster writing up the result himself while acknowledging an OpenAI model produced it. [DEVELOPING, TechCrunch/Fortune] Bubeck has called the broader account "false and inflammatory" and said OpenAI's model "did not use their prompts or proofs" and had no access to the Buckmaster-Alpöge work before its public release; Sam Altman publicly backed Bubeck within roughly half an hour of his statement. [DEVELOPING] Neither account has been independently corroborated this run, and the underlying mathematical claim — that an OpenAI agent swarm solved a Navier-Stokes-adjacent problem in 88 hours — is itself still being evaluated by the math community separately from the authorship dispute. [read]

Separately, Chinese AI lab Z.ai completed roughly \$5B in financing, including a \$2B share placement, earmarked for next-generation GLM foundation models and self-training infrastructure — one of the larger single AI infrastructure raises this issue has tracked, and a reminder that the capital race extends well beyond the US labs this brief covers most often. [NEW]

GEOPOLITICS

ISW's Sept. 15 assessment gave Ukraine's first explicit confirmation that its 3rd Army Corps is running a sustained counteroffensive — Operation Vivaldi — against the Russian salient northwest of Lyman, aimed at disrupting a wider Russian encirclement effort around Ukraine's "Fortress Belt" defensive line; ISW assesses the operation has already achieved that disruption objective. [fact per ISW's own assessment; read attribution is ISW's, not independently verified here] Zelensky restated Ukraine's openness to a mutual ceasefire on energy-infrastructure strikes, echoing a push from President Trump; the Kremlin continues to publicly reject anything short of its maximalist war aims. [fact] Russia struck Kyiv with drones on Sept. 15, killing at least one person and injuring 12, including a fatality at a gas station hit in the attack. [fact] North Korea's Kim Jong Un reaffirmed backing for Russia's war effort in a letter to Putin calling it "sacred," with unconfirmed reports of additional troop deployments beyond the units already committed. [flag: single-sourced this run] Nothing located this run changes the broader picture from the prior issue: no territorial shift on either side beyond the Lyman-area contest, and no new development in the Witkoff-Kushner shuttle diplomacy track since early September. [continuity]

IRAN & HORMUZ

The market mechanism is in the Lead; the diplomatic and ground-level detail is here. Oman's Sept. 13 postponement of the Salalah talks came with no stated cause beyond a need for "consensus," and no new date has been set; diplomats had already been cautioning that

a full reopening requires a separate US-Iran understanding neither side has advanced. [fact] The proposed arrangement under discussion — ships entering the strait via Iranian waters and exiting mostly through Omani territory — remains unimplemented. [fact] The Sept. 13 strike on the tanker El Gaia near Hengam Island is the most recent confirmed attack on shipping in the strait itself, distinct from the Bab el-Mandeb/Red Sea theater, where Houthi forces continue consolidating control of Yemen's coastline seized in the prior issue's window — no new territorial change reported there since. [continuity] The counters (transits, dark-fleet screen, war-risk premia) are in the Board; none moved enough this run to suggest either escalation or a return toward the pre-postponement outlook. With Day 199 of closure now logged by two separate trackers in agreement, the practical situation is unchanged even as the diplomatic track worsens: single-digit daily transits against an 85/day pre-crisis baseline, insurance pricing that's kept most conventional carriers out of the strait for over a week without a fresh quote, and no operator this issue tracked reporting a return to normal routing.

SPORTS

Yankees	Beat Twins 8-3 (9/14) and 8-1 (9/15) at Target Field; aggregate record not reconciled this run [see Board] .
Knicks	Hart extension still unsigned; joked about a reported \$60-62M/3-yr framework against his \$132M max eligibility.
Northwestern	Bye completed; hosts Colorado Sat. 9/19, 6:30p CT.

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged since 9/12: Nvidia-Hugging Face deal terms; Amazon FTC ad-auction suit; Ford/CATL battery scrutiny; Anthropic IPO timeline (still no S-1); Knicks' Hart extension terms. Watch for next issue: today's FOMC statement, dot plot, and whether the hike prices as one-and-done or the start of a series; any new date for Salalah-track talks; independent confirmation of the Yankees' current aggregate record and the 30-year/2-year Tuesday closes

beyond the single snapshot used here; further corroboration (or retraction) of either side's account in the OpenAI-Buckmaster dispute; a fresher Lloyd's List transit figure; European market closes, unlocated this run.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.